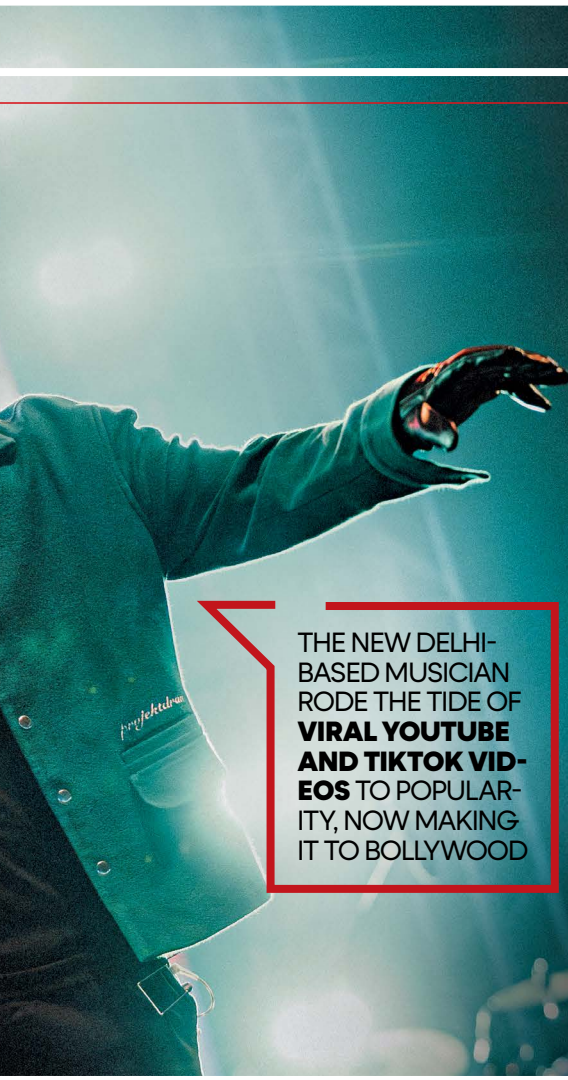


THE NEW DELHI-BASED MUSICIAN RODE THE TIDE OF **VIRAL YOUTUBE AND TIKTOK VIDEOS** TO POPULARITY, NOW MAKING IT TO BOLLYWOOD

Cigarette to upload a lyric video for the tune. Then, the follow-up 'Tu Rehti Hai' was used by the comedy channel Hasley India for one of their clips, the success of which led to his being managed by their talent agency CollabX.

Next, he got his first taste of international recognition when 2022's 'Samjho Na' trended on TikTok—despite being banned in India—and crossed over into Pakistan and the UAE. It was subsequently included, in the form of a duet, on the soundtrack of the 2024 Bollywood smash *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 3*.

In 2025, the *Devdas*-inspired 'Paro' and the uptempo 'Sahiba' went viral and turned into his biggest hits. When he found out he had the most-streamed song in the country, he celebrated the achievement but didn't quite know how to process it. "When I look back, it feels like such a big deal, but at the time, I was just blank," says Rikhari.

Since then, Rikhari—who seems to have mastered pop music's hit formula of simple lyrics, easy melodies and intense emotiveness—has been learning how to make peace with pressure. "I just give myself some time to not think about making music, and then I start from page one," says the artist, who told us he plans to do a lot more collaborations this year.

While he typically takes things as they come, Rikhari has got his fingers crossed for a dream project: providing the playback for a song picturised on Shah Rukh Khan. "Whenever anyone asks me what my favourite food or colour is, I always say, I have only one favourite: Shah Rukh Khan," says Rikhari. "I would love to sing for him someday. I really hope it happens very soon." ■

—Amit Gurbaxani



◀ **FEB. 14** *Shilpakala Vedika, Hyderabad* | **FEB. 21** *Bharat Mandapam, Delhi*

STRING AND WIND

Kotak Private presents *String and Wind*, an immersive Hindustani classical concert exploring two elemental forces of sound. The evening brings together sitar maestro Ustad Shujaat Khan and bansuri virtuoso Pandit Rakesh Chaurasia, whose artistry spans deep classical rigour and meditative expression.

▼ **FEB. 22** | *The Grand Theatre, NMACC, Mumbai*

Mahesh Kale Live with the Budapest Scoring Orchestra

Mahesh Kale, known for his versatility across genres, performs thumri, natyageet and bhajan alongside the Budapest Scoring Orchestra in a sensitive fusion of musical traditions.





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◀ **MAR. 1** | *Tata Theatre, NCPA, Mumbai*

Hori Ke Rang

Celebrating the colours and spirit of Holi, this concert explores classical and semi-classical Hori compositions through melody and devotion. The evening is led by Shubha Mudgal, whose interpretations have always balanced scholarship with emotional immediacy.